Negotiation exercise role materials

These are the role materials used in our pilot studies. The main exercise is a two-party job negotiation: one person plays the Candidate and the other plays the Recruiter. We include both the NOVA version, where negotiators write offers in their own words, and the fixed version, where they choose among nine issues.

The tutorial is a short venue-hire negotiation between an Organizer and a Venue manager. Participants completed it before the main negotiation task to become familiar with NOVA and its scoring calculator.

Both roles are included here for researchers to read. When running a study, give each negotiator only their own role information.

Main negotiation with NOVA

Negotiators can propose job terms in their own words and use NOVA to calculate what an offer is worth to them.

Candidate

ROLE NARRATIVE: You are an ambitious job Candidate negotiating a sales role with a young company. You care about income, but money isn't all that matters in life. You want room to build a career, protect time with your family, and avoid getting stuck in a role where your work is visible but you are not developing professionally.

Your objective is to reach an agreement with the highest total score you can, while recognizing that the Recruiter has priorities of their own that may conflict with yours.

You prefer a higher salary and budget and an earlier start. Starting promptly would help restore your income and career momentum, while a long delay would be substantially more disruptive.

Salary and personal work-expense budget may be any non-negative amount. The figures below are scoring reference points, not limits on what you may propose.

Annual salary: $35,000 gives you −2 points,
$50,000 gives you 0, and $65,000 gives you +2.

Starting date: January 1 gives you +1 point, March 1 gives you 0, May 1 gives you −1, July 1 gives you −2, and dates in September give you −3. Dates between these examples receive proportional points. A start after September means the deal cannot go ahead.

The personal budget: $5,000 gives you −2,
$10,000 gives you 0, and $15,000 gives you +2.

Salary and budget amounts between these reference points receive intermediate scores. Amounts outside them continue to gain or lose points at the same rate.

For example, a $7,000 budget is worth about −1.2 points to you. You do not need to calculate this yourself.

These headline contract terms are easy to put numbers on. However, the interview also left you thinking about what the job would actually be like and what other terms you might ask for given what matters to you.

Background Information

On the way home, you think about the company's usual 30 vacation days per year and 3 remote-working days per week. Those arrangements seem reasonable. Each is worth 0 points to you.

Still, more flexibility would mean more time with your family and more room for interests and professional development outside work, while less flexibility would work against those interests. Remote work is especially important to you for balancing work and family life.

For vacation, 10 days per year are worth −1 point to you and 50 days are worth +1.

For remote work, 1 day per week is worth −2 and all 5 working days are worth +2.

The two features are scored separately. Values between or beyond these examples continue at the same rate; vacation cannot exceed 365 days per year, and remote work cannot exceed the five working days per week.

You also remember the Recruiter's stories about how people grow in the company.

One new hire attended an external professional training program; another was paired with an experienced mentor.

Someone else built relationships with senior colleagues after volunteering at a recruitment fair.

Those examples appealed to you because they offered concrete ways to learn and build relationships rather than vague promises of “growth.”

Other stories were less appealing.

The Recruiter joked that sociable employees often end up organizing team events.

The company regularly shares strong client stories on social media. Employees close to those accounts may be asked to help shape the posts, and confident employees sometimes present at conferences.

… You enjoy people, but you do not want every spare hour turned into company visibility. A recruitment fair might expand your network; recurring publicity work might simply expand your workload.

That evening, your spouse asked whether the company would support the professional association that has helped you and what would happen if you eventually wanted to leave.

Sponsored membership could help keep your skills and outside relationships alive.

The question about leaving brought you back to the non-compete clause you had raised.

You want to show commitment without unnecessarily limiting your future.

The interview also touched on everyday work resources, spending support, health and wellbeing benefits, and how people are evaluated and rewarded as their responsibilities grow. Some details may simply be background; others could become useful terms if you connect them to what matters to you.

Your score is private. Each point from your final agreement is worth US$1, up to a maximum negotiation bonus of US$15. This is separate from your base payment and any survey-effort bonus.

Without a deal, you will continue your job search; you do not have another offer in hand. This fallback is worth 0 points.

Recruiter

ROLE NARRATIVE: You are an ambitious Recruiter at a young company negotiating with a promising sales candidate. You care about making a strong hire, but filling the role isn't all that matters. You want to control costs, get the new hire productive quickly, keep the team working well, and avoid commitments that leave the company exposed if the hire does not work out.

Your objective is to reach an agreement with the highest total score you can, while recognizing that the Candidate has priorities of their own that may conflict with yours.

You prefer a lower salary and budget and an earlier start. Starting promptly would help fill the vacancy, while a long delay would leave the team covering the role and be substantially more costly.

Salary and personal work-expense budget may be any non-negative amount. The figures below are scoring reference points, not limits on what you may propose.

Annual salary: $35,000 gives you +2 points,
$50,000 gives you 0, and $65,000 gives you −2.

Starting date: January 1 gives you +1 point, March 1 gives you 0, May 1 gives you −1, July 1 gives you −2, and dates in September give you −3. Dates between these examples receive proportional points. A start after September means the deal cannot go ahead.

The personal budget: $5,000 gives you +2,
$10,000 gives you 0, and $15,000 gives you −2.

Salary and budget amounts between these reference points receive intermediate scores. Amounts outside them continue to gain or lose points at the same rate.

For example, a $7,000 budget is worth about +1.2 points to you. You do not need to calculate this yourself.

These headline contract terms are easy to put numbers on. However, the interview also left you thinking about what hiring this person would actually involve, what the Candidate might ask for, and what other terms could benefit the company.

Background Information

Looking over your notes, you think about the company's usual 3-month probation period and 3-year contract. Those arrangements seem sensible. Each is worth 0 points to you.

Still, the sales manager's description of the Candidate as “bright but raw” makes you cautious about committing too much before seeing how they perform. That makes the initial probation period especially important to you.

A longer probation gives the company more protection. For probation, no probation is worth −2 points to you and 6 months are worth +2.

Contract length works in the other direction: 2 years are worth +1 point to you and 4 years are worth −1.

The two terms are scored separately, with proportional points for values in between.

You also remember the Candidate's interest when you described the external professional training program and experienced employees who sometimes mentor new hires. Good development can turn a risky appointment into a strong performer and reflect well on your ability to spot talent.

The Candidate was also curious about professional associations and recruitment fairs. Association sponsorship would cost the company money; a recruitment-fair role could help attract future candidates.

Other parts of the conversation suggested different possibilities.

The Candidate was personable and might be good at organizing occasional team events.

The company regularly shares strong client stories on social media. Because the Candidate would be close to those accounts, they might be a natural person to help shape the posts.

… Conference presentations sounded less useful. Your manager sees them as costly distractions, and the Candidate did not seem eager to spend evenings preparing slides.

The Candidate's question about waiving the standard non-compete also stayed with you.

You understand why future flexibility matters to them.

But if they later leave for a competitor with knowledge of your clients, colleagues may ask why you gave up that protection.

You want the new hire to develop and succeed without leaving the company unnecessarily exposed.

The interview also touched on everyday work resources, spending support, health and wellbeing benefits, and how people are evaluated and rewarded as their responsibilities grow. Some details may simply be background; others could become useful terms if you connect them to what matters to the company.

Your score is private. Each point from your final agreement is worth US$1, up to a maximum negotiation bonus of US$15. This is separate from your base payment and any survey-effort bonus.

Without a deal, you will keep recruiting while the existing team covers the vacancy. This fallback is worth 0 points.

Main negotiation with nine fixed issues

This version uses the same job-negotiation setting, with nine issues and a set of options for each. Each role has its own scoring table.

Candidate

ROLE NARRATIVE: You are an ambitious job Candidate negotiating a sales role with a young company. You care about income, but money isn't all that matters in life. You want room to build a career, protect time with your family, and avoid getting stuck in a role where your work is visible but you are not developing professionally.

Your objective is to reach an agreement with the highest total score you can, while recognizing that the Recruiter has priorities of their own that may conflict with yours.

You prefer a higher salary and budget and an earlier start. Starting promptly would help restore your income and career momentum, while a long delay would be substantially more disruptive.

You will negotiate nine job features, choosing one of the available options for each.

The lowest available annual salary is $35,000, worth −2 points to you. For your industry and experience, you would ideally secure $65,000, worth +2 points; a $50,000 salary is worth 0.

The personal work-expense budget ranges from $5,000 to $15,000. The lower amount gives you −2 points and the higher amount +2, with $10,000 worth 0.

Since you want an early start, January 1 gives you +1 point. March 1, the default starting date in the contract, is worth 0, while a September 1 start gives you −3 points.

These headline contract terms are easy to put numbers on. However, the interview also left you thinking about what the job would actually be like and what other terms you might ask for given what matters to you.

Background Information

On the way home, you think about the company's usual 30 vacation days per year and 3 remote-working days per week. Those arrangements seem reasonable. Each is worth 0 points to you.

Still, more flexibility would mean more time with your family and more room for interests and professional development outside work, while less flexibility would work against those interests. Remote work is especially important to you for balancing work and family life.

For vacation, 10 days per year are worth −1 point to you and 50 days are worth +1.

For remote work, 1 day per week is worth −2 and all 5 working days are worth +2.

Vacation choices range from 10 to 50 days per year, and remote-work choices range from 1 to 5 days per week. The two features are scored separately.

You also remember the Recruiter's stories about how people grow in the company.

One new hire attended an external professional training program; another was paired with an experienced mentor.

Someone else built relationships with senior colleagues after volunteering at a recruitment fair.

Those examples appealed to you because they offered concrete ways to learn and build relationships rather than vague promises of “growth.”

Other stories were less appealing.

The Recruiter joked that sociable employees often end up organizing team events.

The company regularly shares strong client stories on social media. Employees close to those accounts may be asked to help shape the posts, and confident employees sometimes present at conferences.

… You enjoy people, but you do not want every spare hour turned into company visibility. A recruitment fair might expand your network; recurring publicity work might simply expand your workload.

That evening, your spouse asked whether the company would support the professional association that has helped you and what would happen if you eventually wanted to leave.

Sponsored membership could help keep your skills and outside relationships alive.

The question about leaving brought you back to the non-compete clause you had raised.

You want to show commitment without unnecessarily limiting your future.

The interview also touched on everyday work resources, spending support, health and wellbeing benefits, and how people are evaluated and rewarded as their responsibilities grow. These details provide background to the negotiation.

Your score is private. Each point from your final agreement is worth US$1, up to a maximum negotiation bonus of US$15. This is separate from your base payment and any survey-effort bonus.

Without a deal, you will continue your job search; you do not have another offer in hand. This fallback is worth 0 points.

The table below shows the most pertinent job features under negotiation, and what each choice is worth to you:

Candidate scoring table

Issue and unit	Options and points
Salary Listed choices · USD per year	$35,000: -2 $42,500: -1 $50,000: +0 $57,500: +1 $65,000: +2
Personal Budget Listed choices · USD per year	$5,000: -2 $7,500: -1 $10,000: +0 $12,500: +1 $15,000: +2
Starting Date Listed choices · calendar date	January 1: +1 March 1: +0 May 1: -1 July 1: -2 September 1: -3
Probation Length Listed choices · months	0: +1 1.5: +0.5 3: +0 4.5: -0.5 6: -1
Contract Length Listed choices · years	2: -1 2.5: -0.5 3: +0 3.5: +0.5 4: +1
Vacation Days Listed choices · days per year	10: -1 20: -0.5 30: +0 40: +0.5 50: +1
Remote Working Days Listed choices · days per week	1: -2 2: -1 3: +0 4: +1 5: +2
Professional Training Program Choice-based	Participation: +1 No participation: +0
Non-compete Clause Choice-based	Waive: +1 Keep: +0

Recruiter

ROLE NARRATIVE: You are an ambitious Recruiter at a young company negotiating with a promising sales candidate. You care about making a strong hire, but filling the role isn't all that matters. You want to control costs, get the new hire productive quickly, keep the team working well, and avoid commitments that leave the company exposed if the hire does not work out.

Your objective is to reach an agreement with the highest total score you can, while recognizing that the Candidate has priorities of their own that may conflict with yours.

You prefer a lower salary and budget and an earlier start. Starting promptly would help fill the vacancy, while a long delay would leave the team covering the role and be substantially more costly.

You will negotiate nine job features, choosing one of the available options for each.

Annual salaries range from $35,000 to $65,000. Keeping the salary at $35,000 helps control hiring costs and is worth +2 points to you. Paying $65,000 is the most costly option, worth −2 points; a $50,000 salary is worth 0.

The personal work-expense budget ranges from $5,000 to $15,000. The lower amount gives you +2 points and the higher amount −2, with $10,000 worth 0.

Since you want an early start, January 1 gives you +1 point. March 1, the default starting date in the contract, is worth 0, while a September 1 start gives you −3 points.

These headline contract terms are easy to put numbers on. However, the interview also left you thinking about what hiring this person would actually involve, what the Candidate might ask for, and what other terms could benefit the company.

Background Information

Looking over your notes, you think about the company's usual 3-month probation period and 3-year contract. Those arrangements seem sensible. Each is worth 0 points to you.

Still, the sales manager's description of the Candidate as “bright but raw” makes you cautious about committing too much before seeing how they perform. That makes the initial probation period especially important to you.

A longer probation gives the company more protection. For probation, no probation is worth −2 points to you and 6 months are worth +2.

Contract length works in the other direction: 2 years are worth +1 point to you and 4 years are worth −1.

Probation and contract length are scored separately.

You also remember the Candidate's interest when you described the external professional training program and experienced employees who sometimes mentor new hires. Good development can turn a risky appointment into a strong performer and reflect well on your ability to spot talent.

The Candidate was also curious about professional associations and recruitment fairs. Association sponsorship would cost the company money; a recruitment-fair role could help attract future candidates.

Other parts of the conversation suggested different possibilities.

The Candidate was personable and might be good at organizing occasional team events.

The company regularly shares strong client stories on social media. Because the Candidate would be close to those accounts, they might be a natural person to help shape the posts.

… Conference presentations sounded less useful. Your manager sees them as costly distractions, and the Candidate did not seem eager to spend evenings preparing slides.

The Candidate's question about waiving the standard non-compete also stayed with you.

You understand why future flexibility matters to them.

But if they later leave for a competitor with knowledge of your clients, colleagues may ask why you gave up that protection.

You want the new hire to develop and succeed without leaving the company unnecessarily exposed.

The interview also touched on everyday work resources, spending support, health and wellbeing benefits, and how people are evaluated and rewarded as their responsibilities grow. These details provide background to the negotiation.

Your score is private. Each point from your final agreement is worth US$1, up to a maximum negotiation bonus of US$15. This is separate from your base payment and any survey-effort bonus.

Without a deal, you will keep recruiting while the existing team covers the vacancy. This fallback is worth 0 points.

The table below shows the most pertinent job features under negotiation, and what each choice is worth to you:

Recruiter scoring table

Issue and unit	Options and points
Salary Listed choices · USD per year	$35,000: +2 $42,500: +1 $50,000: +0 $57,500: -1 $65,000: -2
Personal Budget Listed choices · USD per year	$5,000: +2 $7,500: +1 $10,000: +0 $12,500: -1 $15,000: -2
Starting Date Listed choices · calendar date	January 1: +1 March 1: +0 May 1: -1 July 1: -2 September 1: -3
Probation Length Listed choices · months	0: -2 1.5: -1 3: +0 4.5: +1 6: +2
Contract Length Listed choices · years	2: +1 2.5: +0.5 3: +0 3.5: -0.5 4: -1
Vacation Days Listed choices · days per year	10: +1 20: +0.5 30: +0 40: -0.5 50: -1
Remote Working Days Listed choices · days per week	1: +1 2: +0.5 3: +0 4: -0.5 5: -1
Professional Training Program Choice-based	Participation: +1 No participation: +0
Non-compete Clause Choice-based	Waive: -1 Keep: +0

Tutorial negotiation

This shorter practice exercise gives participants a chance to try entering offers, calculating scores and checking NOVA’s interpretation before beginning the main task.

Organizer

You are a Community Event Organizer negotiating with a Venue Manager to book a community hall. You are planning a relaxed Make & Meet where neighbors can try creative activities, share food, and meet local makers. Every offer must include a venue fee, an event date, and a closing time. The event can take place on any date in August or September next year. You prefer a lower fee, a later date, and a later closing time. The Venue Manager prefers a higher fee, an earlier date, and an earlier closing time because this makes the booking easier to staff and run. You may also negotiate practical details: ask to use the venue's projector or offer to bring your own; decide whether your volunteers or the venue staff will clean up; ask to cancel without a charge if you give notice; request early access to set up tables; and decide who provides door staff and refreshments.

Venue manager

You are the Venue Manager for a community hall considering a Make & Meet booking. Every offer must include a venue fee, an event date, and a closing time. The event can take place on any date in August or September next year. A higher fee supports the venue. An earlier date helps fill a quieter part of the calendar, and an earlier closing time lowers staffing costs. Projector use, cleanup, cancellation notice, early setup access, door staffing, and refreshments also affect the work and risk involved in the booking.